

A FIRM HAND
Bhagwat speaking at a cultural event in Nagpur, Sept. 12

PTI

Steady Anchor

- **Led the RSS through its 100th year, reframing it as a mission for India's future, not a relic of the past**
- **Emerged as a key ideological anchor after the BJP's 2024 setback, shaping its strategic recalibration**
- **Projected *bandhutva*, balance and moral renewal as counterweights to polarisation and excess**

brotherhood, including being a moral guardian to the BJP, exerting a subtle, paternalistic sway. Both his influence and his leaning towards resolution rather than conflict were visible in 2025. In March, Modi made a rare visit to the RSS's Nagpur headquarters, his first in nearly a decade. On August 15, speaking from the Red Fort, he acknowledged the RSS's role in nation-building. The government and the Sangh seemed aligned again—a convergence of interests and intent.

In this climate, Bhagwat's speeches carried renewed weight. When he remarked in early 2025 that "pracharaks retire at 75", it invited close reading: both he and Modi were to cross that milestone in September. Bhagwat had to clarify it was not a coded message, signalling continuity and reverting to larger messaging. At the RSS centenary, he spoke in the tones of an evangelist: "The RSS enters its second century not as a movement of the past, but as a mission for India's future."

Sixteen years into his tenure, Bhagwat has presided over an expansion of the Sangh's institutional footprint. He has also sought to expand its vocabulary: speaking of *bandhutva* (fraternity), opening conversations with Dalit collectives, interfaith groups, even sections of the Left intelligentsia. In his personal austerity, he is a throwback to the renunciatory tradition of his forebears. Standing vigil, as it were, against the modern corruptions of power. Deeper within, there also lurks a moral reformist. ■